> I am now in prison. I know not what is in store for tomorrow. Therefore, I request that the sympathy and affection that you have thus far shown me be turned to our shipping company. Do not think of this as a business venture established for the financial benefit of its shareholders. Rather consider this company as the abode and shrine of our divinely pure Mother India and work for it with filial love and patriotism. If the company should succeed in defeating the conspiracy of our alien enemies it will not merely be the victory of our shareholders but the victory of Swaraj for Mother India. If our company should earn profits overcoming the competition of foreigners it is no mere monetary profit. It amounts to a *national moral gain* through the regaining of our national qualities such as liberty and freedom.

Resignation from the company must have been heart wrenching for VOC. Bharati's description of the company as VOC's child is more than a figure of speech. But the message clearly articulated to those within and outside that SSNCo was *a political and patriotic* venture is significant. 'I know not what is in store for tomorrow', also has an ominous ring to it.

VOC had repeatedly stalled efforts to remove him from the company, holding out defiantly like the rock of Gibraltar. He had resisted Wynch's orders to leave Tuticorin even as the security proceedings were going on. Why then did he yield now?

From his wife Meenakshi's letter we know that he agreed to resign at the instance of P.L. Vengu Aiyar.[16] Vengu Aiyar, as we will recall was a director/legal adviser of SSNCo, against whom Ashe had instituted security proceedings. Vengu Aiyar was present when a convicted VOC was being taken to Coimbatore from Tirunelveli: he had said reassuringly to VOC, 'We will soon get you released!'[17]

With these credentials, he must have been an ideal candidate to talk to VOC. We can imagine what he might have said. Vengu Aiyar probably told him that the fate of the company depended upon his resignation; the company could no longer keep the colonial state at bay. VOC could have hardly accepted that fate. He did what any honourable man would do. He resigned. At that time, Vengu Aiyar, it seems, had made some promises. But unfortunately, for whatever reason, his oral assurances were not confirmed formally. As we shall see, this came back to haunt VOC when the company was liquidated even as he was still in fetters. Not only would it cause